



Abhijit Sinha's Project DEFY creates learning spaces in rural areas. Here he displays a simple circuit piano made by children in a village on the outskirts of Bangalore

Chhabra who run the most popular makerspaces and base their establishments on their experience with contemporaries abroad.

For both, the lack of amenities while trying to prototype in India added fuel to setting up a similar enterprise in the country. Before setting up Maker's Asylum, Chhabra was working with EyeNetra, a mobile eye diagnostic device manufacturer that was testing the product in rural Maharashtra. When he needed to make changes to improve the product, he was forced to send instructions back to the Boston office because he lacked the infrastructure to iterate locally.

Ask him what it takes to start a makerspace in India and he says, "the sky is falling". That's exactly what happened to Chhabra. One day in 2012, the ceiling of the rented office collapsed destroying all the furniture with it. The landlord offered to fix the ceiling but refused to pay for the damaged furniture, explains Chhabra. "So, we decided to build it ourselves," he adds. He put out a message on social media explaining his situation and how he was looking for help. "On the first day, five people showed up. We spent all day building tables. I taught those who didn't know. We had such a good time that when we were done with the tables, we just kept on going," he narrates.

The Asylum's first location was in the store room of Chhabra's old office. Chhabra built his first table at Artisan's Asylum a 40,000 sq ft makerspace in Massachusetts. He can afford to charge a nominal fee to members because corporates too are showing interest in tapping into the diverse community of makers who frequent the space.